the party is reinforcing its status as the senior partner, subtly nudging Nitish into a subservient role. But for Nitish, the move has the trappings of a reluctant bargain, which he hopes will fetch him a stronger deal in the impending seat-sharing negotiations.

Curiously, though, the BJP itself is not entirely at ease with this power play. The most telling sign came from state unit chief Dilip Kumar Jaiswal, who, after quitting his ministerial berth, first declared that the party's parliamentary board would decide the CM candidate, only to later back Nitish Kumar for the top job. It exposed the party's strategic conundrum: the BJP lacks a formidable face of its own in Bihar, yet it is also keenly aware that Nitish Kumar—otherwise the longest-serving CM of the state—is no longer the political magnet he once was.

Adding to the intrigue, neither Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who visited Bihar on February 24, nor BJP national president J.P. Nadda, who was in Patna a day later, categorically endorsed Nitish as the NDA's chief ministerial face. The timing of this pointed ambiguity could not be more significant. On the eve of the cabinet expansion, Nitish's otherwise politically reticent son, Nishant Kumar, made an uncharacteristic public statement, urging the NDA to officially declare his father as its CM candidate. The remark was no innocent observation; it was a calibrated move to pressurise the BJP into a commitment it was reluctant to make. The BJP, as expected, has remained studiously non-committal.

That said, for the BJP, the cabinet reshuffle is not just about cementing its dominance in Bihar's current political landscape. Beneath the surface, the move is also a strategic exercise in caste balancing. The selection of ministers from the Kushwaha, Kurmi, Vaishya and forward-caste communities is a carefully calculated electoral gambit—expanding the BJP's direct engagement with multiple cohorts while reducing its dependence on Nitish's traditional voter base.

And yet, there is one glaring omission—there is not a single Yadav minister in this reshuffle. Yadavs, who constitute 14 per cent of Bihar's electorate, have long been the unwavering foundation of the rival RJD. The message is unmistakable: the BJP has no interest in wooing them. Instead, it is consolidating its hold over the state's broader caste spectrum, positioning itself for the long-term battle ahead.

For Nitish, this is familiar terrain—he has outmanoeuvred allies before, switching sides with calculated precision. But this time, the power dynamics have shifted. The BJP is stronger, and it is less willing to play second fiddle. The big question now is not whether the alliance will hold through the election, but who will truly hold power once the results are in. ■



ANI

SAFFRON SURGE Bihar deputy CM Samrat Chaudhary, BJP state chief Dilip Jaiswal and other leaders at an event in Patna, Jan. 5

POLITICAL POKER

- **With seven new ministers, the BJP's tally in the Bihar cabinet goes up to 21 while the JD(U)'s remains stuck at 13**
- **With this, the BJP is reinforcing its status as the senior partner, having forgone the CM's post despite winning more seats in 2020**
- **The move is also a strategic exercise in caste balancing with ministers selected from Kushwaha, Kurmi, Vaishya and forward-caste communities**
- **For CM Nitish Kumar, it's a reluctant bargain that he hopes will fetch him a stronger deal in the impending seat-sharing negotiations for the 2025 election**